



Surrender of Cornwallis

message included two lists – one with the plain elements in the alphabetical order and code elements in a random arrangement, and the other to help with the decoding where the alphabets and numerals in plaintext were random and the code elements in order. After Rossignol's demise, his son and grandson continued his work. By then, there were many cryptographers in the employment of the French Government. They formed the Cabinet Noir (the Black Chamber).

In the 1700's "Black Chambers" were common in Europe. The largest one, however, was in Vienna, called the Geheime Kabinets-Kanzlei. It was led by Baron Ignaz de Koch and the organization was mainly used to sift through all the mail coming to foreign embassies, copy these letters, reseal and return them to the post office the same morning. The office also took charge of other political or military interceptions. There were almost a hundred letters read in a day.

The English Black Chamber came into existence due to the efforts of John Wallis in 1701. Before that, he had to solve ciphers for the Government from an unofficial position. When he died, his grandson, William Blencowe, coveted the position. Having been taught by his father, Blencowe was granted the title of Decypherer. In the cryptographic world, the English Black Chamber has the longest history of victories.

The Black Chambers of Europe solved many ciphers and were widely successful. But the period of peace tested their usefulness, which was largely miniscule. By 1850, these Black Chambers were dissolved.